

Round 1: Investment Competition

Teams receive a client case study outlining the client's goals, values, risk tolerance, time horizon, and constraints. Each team manages a virtual \$250,000 portfolio from Saturday 3 October to Friday 16 October 2026, investing exclusively in individual company stocks listed on the NASDAQ or NYSE through MarketWatch Virtual Stock Exchange. ETFs, options, derivatives, cryptocurrencies, short selling and margin trading are prohibited (see Portfolio Rules). Teams submit their final portfolio and a written investment rationale by 11:59 pm IST on Saturday 17 October 2026; the top 10 teams advance to the Final Round.

Round 2: Stock Pitch (Underperformer Review)

The top 10 teams continue with the same client case study. Each team selects one stock from its own Round 1 portfolio, still held at the Round 1 close, whose return underperformed the team's overall portfolio return, and delivers a 10-minute pitch followed by 5 minutes of Q&A. The pitch must diagnose why the stock underperformed and recommend whether the client should hold, add to, trim or exit the position. Teams may select the same stock; each team is judged independently on the quality of its own fundamental analysis and valuation, client fit, diagnosis and recommendation, risk assessment, and defence. A short market-update scenario will be released on the day, and teams must explain how the new information affects their recommendation.

Competition Rules

- **Format:** Two rounds. Round 1 runs from Saturday 3 October to Friday 16 October 2026. The first trading session opens at 7:00 pm IST on Monday 5 October, and trading ends at the US market close on 16 October (1:30 am IST, Saturday 17 October). Round 1 submissions are due by 11:59 pm IST on Saturday 17 October 2026; the top 10 teams advance to the Final Round.
- **Capital:** Each team receives a virtual \$250,000 portfolio.
- **Eligible investments:** Only individual company stocks listed on the NASDAQ or NYSE and available on MarketWatch Virtual Stock Exchange are permitted.

*ETFs, options, derivatives, cryptocurrencies, short selling, and margin trading are prohibited.

- **Client:** All investment decisions must reflect the client's goals, values, risk tolerance, time horizon, and stated constraints.
- **Research & AI:** AI tools are permitted for research, idea generation, drafting, calculations, and analysis. However, teams must independently verify every factual claim, statistic, quotation, source, calculation, and AI-generated conclusion using reliable sources or their own working before submission. Teams are fully responsible for the accuracy of all submitted work and must be able to explain and defend their reasoning, assumptions, calculations, and sources during judging. Fabricated data, citations, sources, results, or knowingly submitting unverified AI-generated information is prohibited and may result in penalties or disqualification.
- **Originality & Integrity:** Plagiarism, fabricated information, unauthorized assistance, manipulation of results, or attempts to gain an unfair advantage may result in penalties or disqualification.
- **Submissions:** Round 1 materials must be emailed to xavage@tisb.ac.in by 11:59 pm IST on Saturday 17 October 2026. The email subject must be "Virtual Stock Exchange – Round 1 – [Team Name]". Teams must attach all six required items: (1) final portfolio summary, (2) final allocation (% of portfolio by stock and by sector), (3) transaction history, (4) investment rationale, (5) performance evidence, and (6) source list. The investment rationale should not exceed 3,000 words, excluding tables, charts and the source list. Late or incomplete submissions are subject to the penalties stated below.
- **Conduct:** Teams must maintain professional and respectful conduct throughout the competition.

- **Authority:** The Organizing Committee and judging panel have final authority over rule interpretation, penalties, and disqualification.

Round 1 Rubric:

Round 1 is scored out of 100 using the four sections below. Judges should award marks only for evidence actually shown in the submitted materials.

Section	Criterion	Points	Assessment
CLIENT FIT & INVESTMENT THESIS	Client Fit	15	15: Every holding's allocation size AND stock choice is explicitly and correctly linked to specific client attributes (goals, risk tolerance, horizon, values, constraints) — no generic statements. 13–14: Every holding is linked to the client, but 1–2 links are generic rather than decision-specific. 11–12: At least 75% of holdings are explicitly linked to client attributes. 9–10: About half of holdings are explicitly linked; the rest are undiscussed. 7–8: A minority of holdings are explicitly linked to the client. 5–6: Explains one client attribute that influenced the portfolio but does not link to an individual stock choice. 1–4: Client is mentioned but gives no explanation of how they influenced the portfolio or any investment decision. 0: No reference to the client.
	Thesis	15	15: Every holding has a specific, evidence-backed return driver/catalyst tied to the portfolio thesis. 13–14: Nearly all holdings have a specific driver; one or two are vague. 11–12: At least 75% of holdings have an identifiable driver with some evidence. 9–10: About half of holdings have a stated driver; the rest only describe the company. 7–8: A minority of holdings have an evidenced driver. 5–6: Thesis mostly describes holdings rather than explaining expected returns. 1–4: Portfolio narrative present with no identifiable return logic. 0: No coherent thesis.

RISK & DOWNSIDE ANALYSIS	Risk Identification	15	15: Every holding's key risk is named and its channel of exposure to the portfolio explained. 13–14: Nearly all holdings covered; one or two risks lack an exposure explanation. 11–12: At least 75% of holdings have a named, explained risk. 9–10: About half of holdings have a named risk; explanations are thin. 7–8: A minority of holdings have a risk tied specifically to them. 5–6: Risks are listed at the portfolio level only, not per holding. 1–4: Generic risks stated (e.g. 'the market may fall') with no link to holdings. 0: No risks identified.
	Downside Analysis	15	15: Bear case* is quantified (scenario/sensitivity/drawdown estimate) for the portfolio, with clear thesis-break conditions and mitigation. 13–14: Quantified bear case and thesis-break conditions present; mitigation only partly addressed. 11–12: Bear case is credible with some quantification, but thesis-break conditions are vague. 9–10: Bear case stated in general terms with limited quantification. 7–8: Downside is acknowledged but not modelled or quantified. 5–6: Risks are restated without any downside modelling. 1–4: Risks stated with no analysis of impact. 0: No downside analysis.
TECHNICAL & MARKET ANALYSIS	Technical Analysis	10	9–10: Indicators are correctly applied to multiple holdings and clearly tied to a timing or risk decision. 7–8: Indicators applied correctly but interpretation is thin for some holdings. 5–6: Indicators are present but only loosely connected to decisions. 1–4: Indicators are listed, misused, or disconnected from decisions. 0: No technical analysis.
	Market & Industry Analysis	10	9–10: Sector/macro analysis is provided for every holding and clearly tied to that holding's outlook. 7–8: Sector/macro analysis covers most holdings with clear links. 5–6: Analysis covers the portfolio generally but rarely ties to individual holdings. 1–4: Broad market commentary with little decision relevance. 0: No market/industry analysis.
MARKETWATCH RETURNS	Portfolio Performance	20	Objective: Based on final MarketWatch ranking among all eligible teams, scaled so that 1st place = 20 and last place = 0: $\text{points} = 20 \times (N - \text{rank}) \div (N - 1)$, where N is the number of eligible teams, rounded to the nearest whole point. Teams with identical returns share the higher rank. Returns do not override rule breaches; penalties are applied after rubric scoring.

*Bear Case: A structured argument highlighting risks, headwinds, and potential for underperformance.

SCORING: Add the four section totals to obtain a score out of 100, then apply any rule penalties. TIEBREAKER: (1) Client Fit & Investment Thesis, (2) Risk & Downside Analysis, (3) Technical & Market Analysis, (4) MarketWatch Returns.

Round 2 Rubric:

The Final Round is scored out of 100 across five sections. Judges assess the stock pitch and the team's response to the on-the-day market-update scenario.

Section	Criterion	Points	Assessment
FUNDAMENTAL ANALYSIS & VALUATION	Fundamental Analysis & Valuation	20	19–20: Every relevant financial metric, the business model, competitive position and valuation (e.g. multiples vs. peers or history, or an intrinsic-value estimate vs. the current price) are used, each explicitly tied to what has driven the stock's performance and what it implies going forward. 17–18: Nearly all elements present and linked to performance; one is under-explained. 15–16: At least 75% of the analysis is present with clear links to performance. 13–14: About two-thirds of the analysis is present and linked to performance. 11–12: About half of the analysis is linked to performance; the rest is descriptive only. 9–10: A noticeable share of the analysis is generic company description rather than performance-linked. 7–8: Only isolated metrics are used, mostly without explanation. 5–6: A few facts about the company are stated with almost no analytical link. 1–4: Mostly company description with no real financial analysis. 0: No fundamental analysis.

CLIENT FIT & INVESTMENT THESIS	Client Fit	10	9–10: The recommendation (hold/add/trim/exit) is explicitly linked to at least three specific client attributes and the stock's ongoing role in the portfolio. 7–8: Linked to two client attributes with a stated portfolio role. 5–6: Linked to one client attribute; portfolio role is unclear. 1–4: Client is referenced generically without a specific link to this decision. 0: No reference to the client.
	Investment Thesis	20	19–20: Gives 3–4 specific, evidenced reasons for the underperformance and a clear, evidence-backed recommendation (hold/add/trim/exit) for the position. 17–18: 3 specific, evidenced reasons given; recommendation is clear but one link to evidence is thin. 15–16: 2 reasons given with solid evidence and a stated recommendation. 13–14: 2 reasons given; recommendation present but reasoning is partly generic. 11–12: 1–2 reasons given without a strongly evidenced recommendation. 9–10: One clear, evidenced reason for the underperformance is given. 7–8: Reasons are named but not evidenced. 5–6: General statement that the stock 'underperformed' without specific reasons. 1–4: No clear diagnosis of why the stock underperformed. 0: No diagnosis or recommendation.
RISK & DOWNSIDE ANALYSIS	Risk & Bear Case	20	19–20: Risks to the recommendation are ranked by materiality, potential impact is quantified, and specific conditions that would change the recommendation are stated. 17–18: Impact is quantified and risks are prioritised; conditions that would change the recommendation are only partly specified. 15–16: Bear case is credible with quantification for most risks. 13–14: Bear case is credible with some quantification, but risks are not clearly prioritised. 11–12: Risks are relevant with limited quantification. 9–10: Risks are named and impact is only partly analysed. 7–8: Risks are named but impact is not analysed. 5–6: A short generic risk list is given with minimal detail. 1–4: Risks mentioned only in passing. 0: No risk analysis.

TECHNICAL & MARKET ANALYSIS	Market, Industry & Technical Context	15	15: Industry, macro and technical evidence are all integrated, each explicitly tied to what caused (or masks) the stock's underperformance. 13–14: Most elements integrated and linked; one is under-explained. 11–12: Good context provided but one category (industry/macro/technical) is missing a clear link. 9–10: Some context given with partial links to the stock's performance. 7–8: Mostly background information with limited connection to the stock. 5–6: Indicators or industry facts are listed without interpretation. 1–4: Context is present but disconnected from the stock's performance. 0: No market/industry/technical context.
PRESENTATION, Q&A & SCENARIO RESPONSE	Presentation & Q&A	10	9–10: Within time and fully structured; every question is answered directly with a defended assumption or calculation. 7–8: Clear and mostly within time; one or two answers lack full justification. 5–6: Understandable but disorganised or over time; some questions answered incompletely. 1–4: Unclear, heavily read, or the team cannot defend key claims. 0: Not completed.
	Market-Update Scenario	5	5: Explains the specific mechanism by which the update changes the diagnosis, risk and/or recommendation, with justified reasoning. 3–4: Identifies the right direction of impact but the mechanism or justification is incomplete. 1–2: Asserts a reaction with little or no reasoning. 0: Not addressed.

SCORING: Add all five section totals for a score out of 100. TIEBREAKER: (1) Fundamental Analysis & Valuation, (2) Client Fit & Investment Thesis, (3) Risk & Downside Analysis, (4) Presentation, Q&A & Scenario Response, (5) Technical & Market Analysis.

Portfolio Rules

1. Each team will receive **\$250,000 in virtual funds** on MarketWatch.
2. Teams may invest only in individual company shares listed on the NYSE or Nasdaq and available on MarketWatch Virtual Stock Exchange.
3. ETFs, options, derivatives, cryptocurrencies, short selling, and margin trading are prohibited.
4. Each portfolio must contain **5–12 stocks** from at least **three different sectors**.
5. No more than **25%** of the portfolio may be invested in one stock, and no more than **50%** in one sector.
6. Teams may retain a maximum of **15%** of their starting capital as cash.
7. Rules 4–6 are checked on the final portfolio at the Round 1 close. In addition, no purchase may take a single stock above 25% or a single sector above 50% of portfolio value at the time of purchase. Sectors follow the 11 GICS sectors; where sources disagree, the Organizing Committee's classification is final.
8. Every investment must reflect the client's goals, values, risk tolerance, time horizon and constraints.

9. Portfolio changes are permitted during the competition, but all significant transactions (any single trade worth more than 5% of portfolio value at the time) must be explained in the investment rationale.
10. Each team may operate only **one official MarketWatch portfolio**. Portfolios cannot be restarted.
11. Trading ends at the US market close on Friday 16 October 2026 (4:00 pm ET = 1:30 am IST, Saturday 17 October). The final portfolio value displayed on MarketWatch after that close will be used to calculate returns.
12. Teams must email all six required submission items (final portfolio summary, final allocation, transaction history, investment rationale, performance evidence and source list) to xavage@tisb.ac.in by 11:59 pm IST on Saturday 17 October 2026.
13. Penalties: each ineligible holding = -5 points; missing required submission item = -2 points per item; late submission = -5 points per 24 hours or part thereof. Fabricated evidence, manipulated results, plagiarism, or deliberate rule circumvention may result in disqualification.

Client: Mark Cuban

Brief Summary of Our Client

Mark Cuban is an American entrepreneur, investor and TV personality. He sold his first big company, Broadcast.com, to Yahoo in 1999. He later became a "Shark" on *Shark Tank* and owned the Dallas Mavericks, who won the NBA title in 2011. In 2022 he co-founded Cost Plus Drugs, a pharmacy company that sells generic medicine at low, transparent prices. He also runs a foundation that offers free AI bootcamps to high school students. He is known for backing ideas that cut out middlemen and lower costs for ordinary people.

Personal Information

- **Name:** Mark Cuban
- **Born:** 31 July 1958 in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania (age 68 as of 2026)
- **Education:** Indiana University Bloomington
- **Family:** Married to Tiffany Stewart, with three children

Business career:

- Sold Broadcast.com to Yahoo in 1999 and became a billionaire.
- Founded or co-founded AXS TV, HDNet and 2929 Entertainment.
- Investor ("Shark") on *Shark Tank* for 14 years; left the show after Season 16 (2025).
- Co-founded Cost Plus Drugs in 2022. It is a public benefit corporation that skips pharmacy middlemen and sells medicine at cost plus a fixed markup.
- Sold a majority of the Dallas Mavericks and remains a minority owner.

Philanthropy:

- The Mark Cuban Foundation runs a free, 20-hour AI bootcamp for high school students in grades 9 to 12.
- It focuses on underserved students and is held in many US cities each year.
- Students learn hands-on with real AI tools, then build a project with mentors.

1) What Matters to Him

Fair prices and no middlemen. His biggest recent project exists to make healthcare cheaper by removing the layers that add cost. He likes companies that treat customers fairly, keep pricing clear and win by being better value. He tends to distrust businesses that profit from confusion or hidden fees.

Technology and AI. He follows AI closely and believes it will reshape almost every industry. He wants young people, especially those from underserved backgrounds, to learn it early. He is drawn to companies that use technology to make things faster, cheaper or more accessible.

Entrepreneurship and competition. He backs founders and believes competition is the best way to fix broken industries. He respects companies that challenge big incumbents, and he also respects established leaders that

keep improving and defending their position.

Smart, informed bets. He prefers to invest in what he understands and can explain in plain language. He expects a clear reason behind every pick, and he is not impressed by hype alone.

Sports and entertainment. Sports, media and live events have been part of his career for decades. He sees them as businesses with loyal audiences and lasting demand.

These are ideas to build on, not rules. Competitors can choose any stocks they can justify.

2) What He Wants From the Portfolio

- **Starting amount:** \$250,000.
- **Goal:** Grow the money steadily over the long term. He wants real growth, not just safety, and he expects the portfolio to do better than a simple index fund over time.
- **Risk comfort:** He is comfortable with above-average risk, since he built his wealth by backing bold ideas. He does not want one bad bet to wreck the portfolio. He would accept short-term swings if the reasoning holds up, but not reckless concentration.
- **Balance:** He wants a mix of proven, stable companies that anchor the portfolio, and a smaller set of higher-growth ideas that could add extra return.
- **Understandable holdings:** Every stock should have a simple story he could explain to someone else. If a pick needs a long technical justification, he will be skeptical.
- **Patience:** He is investing for the long term. He does not want a portfolio that depends on constant trading or on predicting the next few weeks.

3) Rules

- Only individual company stocks listed on the Nasdaq or NYSE
- All holdings in US dollars
- No ESG requirement

Questions for Competitors

1. Which themes match his story (healthcare and pharmacy, AI and technology, consumer businesses, sports and media)?
2. How will you balance bigger, steadier companies against smaller, higher-growth ones?
3. How will you spread your money so one stock cannot sink the portfolio?
4. What is the reason behind each stock you choose?
5. How will you balance a three-week competition window against his long-term horizon?